

stockbrokers and financial advisors can be researched using the North American Securities Administrators Association's database at NASAA.org. There are over 900,000 individuals, located across Canada and the United States, in the database. If you can't find your stockbroker or financial advisor in this database, it's a big red flag.

3. **Choose an advisor with a proven track record.** As the chairman of O'Leary Funds, I meet thousands of financial advisors and stockbrokers every year. I've met great advisors, male and female. What's most important is choosing someone you're comfortable with and are certain will do a good job. Very often, successful investment advisors form teams. This happens when their assets under management grow into the billions. You often find women on these teams because they are excellent at preserving capital and providing returns for their clients. I'm not saying women are always better advisors; all I'm saying is that many have a proven track record of success in this industry, and if you've got a good team on your side, you're always going to be in a better position to gain.
4. **Diversify advisors, too.** If you are a couple, never put both your accounts with the same advisor or financial services firm. You need to have your own relationship with an advisor, with no conflict of interest. Even if you never separate or divorce, the diversification that two accounts in two different firms provides is better than having all your family's money in one institution managed by the same person.
5. **Understand return on capital vs. return of capital.** In order to get returns, advisors must take risks with your capital, but if they're taking excessive risks, you're not going to have your capital returned. Ask your advisor to show you a model portfolio and see what is in it. Does the portfolio have more than 5 percent in any one investment? Is it mostly comprised of 50 percent dividend-paying stock and 50 percent interest-bearing bonds? If so, that's a good start. Now ask for the advisor's track record to see how they have performed after fees. In most cases, you're